especially Maham Anaga, must have felt the need to maintain the fragile equilibrium between Akbar's happiness and Bairam Khan's ambitions. We will see, later in this chapter, how Maham Anaga is thought to have played a key role in the deposing of Bairam Khan but, for the moment, she was careful not to antagonize him.

The Mughal court continued its peregrinations, leaving for Delhi, 'dispensing justice and indulging in revelry' en route. Measures were slowly put in place to curtail Bairam Khan's power and all the ministers and amirs now met twice a week in the imperial audience hall where all important matters were first presented to Akbar, who then approved the decisions taken. Once in Delhi, however, the Padshah resumed his favourite activities and one day, while riding on a raging mast elephant called Lakhna, he was flung to the ground and nearly crushed to death. While his servants and attendants wailed and lamented, Akbar got back onto the elephant and brought him under control. Akbar, it would seem, was testing his strength and his courage beyond endurance and almost beyond reason.

After six months in Delhi, the Mughal court got ready to move to Agra by boat. Sikandar Shah had been neutralized and the Punjab somewhat secured. The remaining Afghan noblemen had, however, relocated to Bihar and Bengal. Delhi was too far north to deal with these affairs and so Agra, 240 kilometres further south, was chosen as the new capital. Boats and skiffs were decorated, their seats covered with fine fabrics, while banners snapped in the sudden breeze that had sprung up. All the important amirs had ordered boats to be decorated for their retinues, too, so as the court set sail on the wide and placid Yamuna it looked like 'the river itself had been decorated for a festival or tulips and lilies had poked their heads out from the water'. The Mughals fished and hunted along the way and the voyage was marked by celebrations and a clangorous din. Three weeks later, on 30 October 1558, the court reached Agra, 'the water and air of which put Baghdad with its Tigris and Cairo with its Nile to shame'. The city seems to have been much improved since the time, thirty years earlier, when Babur passed through and wrote in utter contempt that 'the grounds were so bad and unattractive that we traversed them with a hundred disgusts and repulsions'. Akbar now settled into the old Badalgarh* Fort while mansions and gardens were built on both banks of the Yamuna for the amirs and their attendants.